

India Free Fires in Esports World Cup 2026

Two Esports clubs from India qualified for the final round of Free Fire at the Esports World Cup, in what was the country's **first-ever presence** at that stage in the tournament.

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There is something about banned games and India's resurgence. Gamers from the country have made inroads in PUBG: Battlegrounds Mobile, now known as Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI), which was initially banned in 2020. In 2026, it broke another glass ceiling: Indian clubs participated in Free Fire for the first time – a game that was also forbidden in the country for about a year.

Three esports clubs from India – Apex Gaming, S8UL Sports and Total Gaming – qualified for the tournament, with two of them, Apex and S8UL, progressing beyond the survival round.

In the survival stage, Apex finished second with 165 points, while S8UL, with 151 points, claimed the last qualifying spot for the final round. The impressive runs came to an agonising end in the finals. Apex finished last with 41 points despite placing fourth in two of the seven matches, while S8UL managed 54 points to finish one place higher.

While India's title challenge faded, Lyon from Mexico seized the opportunity, clinching the title, having closed out the competition immediately after reaching Champion Rush Point following Game 6.

The finish may sound uninspiring for most. But to a dedicated Free Fire audience from India, watching the contest in the Esports World Cup for the first time, it surely was a sign of better things ahead. And the game benefited from the viewership, too.

Free Fire at the Esports World Cup became the most-watched tournament for the game in four years,

with viewers from India taking up a chunk of the traction through Hindi streaming. According to Esports charts, the event recorded a peak viewership of 8,02,488 and the YouTube channel Snax Gaming (Hindi stream) was the channel with the second-highest peak viewership.

India confirms squad for Honor of Kings in Esports Nations Cup

India's Honor of Kings squad for the Esports Nations Cup 2026 was announced on Tuesday, with Ainul 'Senpai' Haidery leading the team in the tournament scheduled in Riyadh later this year.

NODWIN Gaming, India's National Team Partner for the Nations Cup, announced the full team, which will compete between November 2 and 29 in Saudi Arabia.

Led by Revenant Xspark's Ainul 'Senpai' Haidery, one of India's leading Junglers, the team also features one of the country's finest Clash Lane players in Deadshot. The duo recently won the Bengaluru leg of the Kings Arise India City Tour. Moreover, Indonesian coach Gradyano Valendy (Rinnqt) will oversee India's preparations for ENC 2026.

The finals of Honor of Kings at ENC 2026 will take place from November 24 to 29, featuring 24 national teams competing for a prize pool of USD 1.32 million (~INR 12.5 crore). A total of 64 countries and territories have officially submitted and confirmed their participation in the tournament.

India's full Honor of Kings squad at ENC 2026

Rahul Lavhate (Kyurem), Aashish Chouhan (Deadshot), Ainul Haidery (Senpai), Saurabh Jagadale (Kael), Bezalel Hmar (Eto)

Substitutes: Aryan Gulati (TT), Saad Sardar (Darkness)